Indo-Pacific. Its participation in bilateral, trilateral and multilateral naval exercises in the Pacific Ocean carried its own significance. The steady externalization of its economy and focus towards the East made it sensitive to maritime security and safety. The conceptual justification for the Indo-Pacific, therefore, centres around the expanding interests of India. It is buttressed by its self-perception as a rule-abiding power that contributes to the global commons. Its core interests may be in the Indian Ocean, but a presence beyond also ensures a peaceful periphery. And since maritime activity has such a profound impact on overall equations, India's participation goes some way in contributing to stability in Asia.

While much of the attention focuses on the expansion of its interests, where India can really make a difference is in the Indian Ocean itself. This is not just a natural arena for its influence but one of overriding security consequence. By maintaining a strong posture there, India's value rises and ensures a more enthusiastic welcome further East. For India, getting its Indo-Pacific approach right rests on ensuring that it works out its Indian Ocean strategy even more correctly. After years of being in denial of a changing reality, India had to come to terms with the fact that there were now more forces at work in the oceans below. That acceptance drove the fashioning of the first integrated maritime outlook in 2015, appropriately articulated as SAGAR (Security and Growth for All in the Region). Premised on the belief that advancing cooperation and using our capabilities for larger good would benefit India, this has four key elements.

The first is to safeguard our mainland and islands, defend our interests, ensure a safe, secure and stable Indian Ocean, and make available our capabilities to others. The second focuses on deepening economic and security cooperation with our maritime neighbours and strengthening their capacities. The third envisages collective action and cooperation to advance peace and security and respond to emergencies. And the fourth seeks a more integrated and cooperative future for the region that enhances sustainable development. SAGAR drives a more active and outcome-oriented Indian approach that enhances its influence by delivering on partnerships. It is translated into hinterland linkages and strengthened regionalism, maritime contributions and support, and the creation of an extended neighbourhood. It comes with a willingness to assume